

no payment at all was recorded! That didn't make front page news, did it? It's like some sort of secret society from the dark ages still exists.

Legal scams in the lending industry happen every day, ripping off the American citizen. You sign up for a credit card with a credit limit of \$1000. The credit card company allows you to charge over the limit; they don't tell you that you have gone over your limit because they want you to do it so they can then slap you with an over-limit fee. You may pay timely every month, but if one time, for whatever circumstance, you pay a day late, you could be hit with a \$29, \$39, or \$49 late payment fee. The credit card companies structure your minimum payment amount so if that is all you ever pay, you will be paying forever. They don't want you to pay it off. They want you to pay a little every month so they can keep their hand in your wallet. The interest will continue to accrue faster than you can pay down the balance. You make the minimum monthly payment, month after month, and yet the balance never seems to get smaller. You begin to feel like the proverbial hamster on the wheel, working up a sweat and going nowhere.

I Like This Guy

Let me tell you a story, a true story that was printed in the *Houston Chronicle* about one ordinary man, just like you and me, who used his credit card to pay for his lunch one day. Hale Hilsabeck owns a karate school in Denver. He is an average tax paying citizen who pays his bills timely. In March 2005, his \$12 charge for his lunch unwittingly put him over his credit limit on his MasterCard by \$1.91. His monthly billing statement showed up a couple weeks later, and they had hit him with a \$35 charge for going over the credit limit. He paid the minimum payment and did not use that card again. However, his minimum payment did not bring him below his credit limit so the next month he was again charged an over-limit fee.

He called the credit card issuer to complain about the second fee and was told nothing could be done and that he should apply for a higher credit limit. When the next bill arrived, there was yet a third over-limit fee due to the fact that he did not pay the second fee, which kept him over the credit limit. Tired of the game, and the \$105 in